

Sony WF-1000XM5

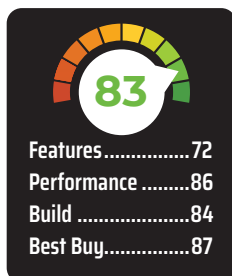
The best TWS earbuds money can buy

There are certain products which you think are perfect and next year, the brand comes out with something that is even better. You know the feeling of getting your hands on it and going like - 'How did they manage that?' Well, the Sony WF-1000XM5 is exactly that product. Granted, the WF-1000XM4 were a pair of TWS earbuds that were not perfect, but the improvements that Sony brought in with the XM5 were enough to invoke that feeling in me and everyone else around the Test Centre who used it. I got my first taste of the improvements when I went for the official India launch of the earbuds. And, when I got to testing them, every step of the way, my mind was blown, except for one instance, where I was like - Ah, this could have been better.

Well, before I spill out all my feelings for the winner of the Digit Zerol Award and the Digit Best Buy Award 2023 in the Premium TWS category, let's dive into the review of the Sony WF-1000XM5. Starting with the build and design -

BUILD AND DESIGN

The build and design of the Sony WF-1000XM5 is the first area where you see massive improvements come in with these earbuds. The size of the earbuds, their fit, and the size of the case have decreased significantly. From my experience with the 1000XM4, this is a massive upgrade. Now, I do not feel that the earbuds will fall off my ears because they are smaller and also come with better-fitting foam ear tips in the box. The design has gotten much sleeker, with Sony ditching the edgy and boxier design of the earbuds from the 1000XM4. The same is with the case for earbuds. It is much smaller than its predecessor's and fits beautifully in the small pocket of my jeans.



That is something I always look for because that is the only instance when I am actually using that pocket.

Leave apart why I love the reduced size of the case; as you can see, it is almost the same size as that of the Apple AirPods Pro Gen 2 case, which has been considered by many

across the industry as the ideal case size for an earbuds case. With size reduction, you also get weight reduction, with the 1000XM5 weighing 2.8 grams less than the 1000XM4. However, the battery life of the case has gone up, and the drivers are bigger, too, with the 1000XM5 packing in 8.4 mm drivers compared to the 6 mm drivers of the 1000XM4.

As for the build quality, Sony's push for using recycled materials carries through into the 1000XM5. Both the case and the earbuds are built well, with the case not picking up any scratches during my extended time of use. Mind that I often tend to keep my keys in the same pocket as the earbuds, which inadvertently scratches the case of the buds that I am using. However, the Sony WF-1000XM5's

case did not pick up any scratches during my time of use, which is impressive. The four different sizes of foam ear tips do pick up gunk. However, they can be cleaned very easily, and the double layer of protection on the nozzle also helps prevent clogging if you are someone whose earbuds are prone to it.

This is where my two gripes with these earbuds come in. I understand that Sony is pushing for the earbuds to be made out of 100 per cent recycled materials, but the lack of a metallic hinge on the case takes away a lot of confidence when I am snapping the lid open and closing. Just that bit, if it was metallic, would have been great, especially considering the price of the earbuds, which sits at ₹24,990. Second is the glossy finish on the buds. Now, given the way that these earbuds sit in the case, the glossy finish on the side of the buds, often led to my fingers slipping off the buds and me dropping them when I was taking them out of the case. The magnets holding the earbuds in are strong. They prevent the earbuds from dropping off in cases where I accidentally opened the case upside down. However, when it is the right side up, I find it difficult to take off without being extra cautious. A notch on the buds or a grippier finish, like that on the WF-1000XM4, would have definitely helped in this case.

Now, let's take a look at the features of the Sony WF-1000XM5.

FEATURES

In my testing, the Sony WF-1000XM5 ticked almost all the boxes on the test sheet. I will keep this section short. These earbuds have the best in class ANC, which I will detail later in the review; the controls are responsive and intuitive and add to the overall experience of using the earbuds. The app going with these earbuds is the Sony Headphones Connect app. If you have read any of our reviews of a pair of Sony TWS earbuds, you will know that we are fans of the app. It allows for an unparalleled level of customisation and features that will help you make these earbuds truly your own.

Sony has added features like Ambient Sound control, which adjusts the ANC